the Opposition Ramesh Chennithala has also thrown his hat in the ring and has reportedly presented his demands to senior Congress leaders.

On May 5, leaders of the Venugopal faction greeted him at New Delhi airport with flowers and drumbeats. They claim that KC has the backing of 43 MLAs, besides the victorious CPI(M) rebels. Satheesan loyalists weren't too far behind—they organised a massive welcome at Ernakulam South railway station when he arrived from Thiruvananthapuram. Meanwhile, the IUML, which has 22 legislators, is demanding the deputy CM's post. The Congress high command will have a tough time dealing with all the aspirants as Kerala braces for a power shift.

The CPI(M)'s Many Woes

Kerala was the last bastion of the Left in India, and Kannur, from where the redoubtable Pinarayi Vijayan hails, its citadel. With the CPI(M) top brass confident of a third consecutive victory, no one imagined it would be breached. After all, hadn't Pinarayi led the team to victory in 2021 with 99 seats, improving the LDF's tally despite the customs gold smuggling scam that hit his office and family?

This time around, Pinarayi could not deliver. Results day left the CPI(M) in tatters, its tally down to just 26 seats. As many as 13 ministers in the outgoing Pinarayi government lost in the polls, including health minister Veena George, industries minister P. Rajeev, higher education minister R. Bindu, and transport minister K.B. Ganesh Kumar. The Communist Party of India (CPI), a major constituent of the LDF, has also been racked by discontent within its ranks. It contested 25 seats, but won only eight.

Pinarayi himself was tested by lightweight Congress candidate V.P. Abdul Rasheed in home constituency Dharmadam in Kannur, trailing in the first seven rounds of counting, before finally winning by 19,000-odd votes (compared to 50,123 votes in 2021). Clearly, exit orders also came from CPI(M) supporters who were disappointed with the leadership for a variety of reasons, ranging from policy issues to nepotism. The party's failure to tackle the grievances of a group of veteran leaders, in particular those in Kannur who contested as independents with UDF support, also hurt the CPI(M) in many strongholds.

Observers cite four major reasons for Pinarayi's fall in Kerala: the CPI(M)'s extravagant spending on party events; insensitivity towards protests, especially that of the ASHA workers for a wage hike; the Sabarimala gold theft case and the failure to gauge the public mood of anti-incumbency. "A government may fail in delivering, but it must have the magnanimity to admit its failures, explain the reasons for it," says veteran CPI leader C. Divakaran, a former minister. "Pinarayi lost touch with people, failed to sense their mood."

The emergence of high-profile rebels close to the election also came as a major setback. Former CPI(M) Kannur district secretariat member T.K. Govindan quit the party to protest against the party fielding P.K. Shyamala, wife of party state secretary M.V. Govindan, in Taliparamba. T.K. Govindan won here by over 12,000 votes, with support from the Congress. Similarly, V. Kunhikrishnan, another CPI(M) district secretariat member in Payyannur, demanded a probe into the alleged mismanagement of a martyr's fund in which party MLA M.I. Madhusoodanan was allegedly involved and quit the party. Kunhikrishnan won Payyannur by 7,000 votes against Madhusoodanan. In Ambalappuzha near Alappuzha, G. Sudhakaran, veteran CPI(M) leader and former minister, also quit the party and contested with UDF support. He won by 13,807 votes. Places like Payyannur and Taliparamba are known as 'party villages', and the wins of CPI(M) rebels there—and the attendant drain of thousands of cadre votes—was a bitter blow.

In the eight constituencies the CPI(M) contested in Kannur district, it lost around 84,000 votes it had won in 2021; the UDF gained 144,703 votes in 2026. The Congress won five out of the 11 constituencies in the district. "I had warned them many times regarding the functioning of party machinery," says T.K. Govindan. "They (party leadership) were reluctant to take corrective steps."

In fact, this nagging discontent against the party leadership even



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The main reasons for the LDF's fall are: extravagant party events; insensitivity towards protests, especially that of ASHA workers; the Sabarimala gold theft case and a personality cult blind to anti-incumbency